KMT base at that time. It came to be known as the Northern Expedition and succeeded, in a period of three years, in unifying the country by defeating the various warlords and their armies.

The Agrarian Revolution brought into prominence Mao Zedong's ideological contribution of making the Chinese peasantry, rather than the urban working class, the advance guard of revolution. This became particularly relevant when the leader of the KMT, Chiang Kai-shek, broke his alliance with the CPC at the end of the Northern Expedition. When CPC cadres moved to establish a strong presence in Shanghai in 1927, Chiang Kai-shek unleashed his troops against them and virtually eliminated the Party leadership. The remnant CPC cadres, including Mao Zedong and Zhou Enlai, retreated into the remote rural areas of China. This is when the CPC became receptive to Mao's idea of the revolution being led from the rural areas and with the peasantry as its main force rather than being based in the cities and mobilizing the urban working class. During this early stage of the revolution, Mao advocated alliance with elements from the richer peasants and the urban bourgeoisie who were willing to join the revolution. Soviet-influenced cadres favoured a more urban-oriented struggle, promoting workers' strikes and conventional pitched battles with the KMT troops. It was Mao who worked out the strategy of setting up revolutionary bases in China's rural hinterland, and of using the villages to surround the cities. He asserted categorically that the Party must rule the gun and that political power could only be achieved through armed force, that power flows 'from the barrel of the gun'. His theory of people's war gave birth to guerrilla warfare and had a major influence on military strategies across the world. It is encapsulated in the following directives issued by Mao and included in the Resolution:

> The enemy advances, we retreat; the enemy camps, we harass; the enemy tires, we attack; the enemy retreats, we pursue.
>
> To extend stable base area, employ the policy of advancing in waves; when pursued by a powerful enemy, employ the policy of circling around.
>
> Lure the enemy in deep.
>
> Concentrate superior forces, pick out the enemy's weak spots, and fight when you are sure of wiping out part, or the greater part, of the enemy in mobile warfare, so as to crush the enemy